Additionally, SLORC intensified a smear campaign against Aung San Suu Kyi. The focus of the attack was centered on her time away from Burma as well as her British husband, Michael Aris, and her supposed ties to elements of the communist party. Furthermore, the regime claimed that Suu Kyi was tainted by Western values. These tactics proved counterproductive as Suu Kyi's popularity continued to rise. A worried military decided to place both Aung San Suu Kyi and Tin U under house arrest.

In the summer of 1989, in order to add credibility to the communist accusation, the tatmadaw released “Burma Communist Party's Conspiracy to Take over State Power.” This lengthy document accused the leadership of the NLD of being in collusion with the communists. To further the conspiracy charges, the Ministry of Information issued an additional 300-page manuscript detailing major enemies of the state. Included in this work was rightist factions, journalists, foreign diplomats, U.S. Congressional members, minority populations, especially the Karens, and of course the key NLD leaders Suu Kyi and Tin U. These massive conspiracy theories were for the most part ignored by the general population.

Concern emerged over a potential split in the tatmadaw as Suu Kyi's creditability increased. The regime continued with an aggressive public relations campaign centered on discounting the atrocities of 1988 along with the essential role played by the tatmadaw in keeping Burma safe and secure. The underlying culprit working against Burma was foreign elements. Western media and human rights organizations constituted a new form of colonialism. This xenophobia has plagued the leadership of Burma for most of its history.

THE ELECTIONS OF 1990: TRIUMPH AND TRAGEDY IN MODERN BURMA

In early 1990, the two top leaders of the NLD Aung San Suu Kyi and Tin U were both disqualified from running for office. With literally thousands of party members incarcerated by early 1990, a discussion ensued within the NLD as to whether to boycott the elections. The regime made it clear that outside monitoring would not be allowed. The creditability of the